

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

ELECTION 2027 CHICAGO MAYOR

Candidates talk tough on crime

Contenders highlight issue despite steep drop in homicides since 2022

By Jake Sheridan and Alice Yin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As Illinois Comptroller Susana Mendoza strode toward the camera in an empty lot, she gave credit for Chicago’s plunging violence, but not to the man she’s hoping to succeed. Homicides have dropped

because “Chicago has the best trauma surgeons,” while shootings are in fact up, she said in a video posted to social media this month — a claim at odds with police data that shows shootings are marginally down this year.

“Trauma surgeons saving more lives is great, but we shouldn’t be taking a victory lap,” she said against a backdrop of wailing police squad car sirens and flashing lights. “As mayor, I’m not going to hide behind statistics. I’m going to have honest

conversations about the level of violent crime across our city.”

It was an effort to spin a fact that could play a key role in Chicago’s February mayoral election: Homicides and shootings have sharply dropped during Mayor Brandon Johnson’s first term, along with declines in several other categories, according to police data. But presented with those numbers, Mendoza said when her video was filmed earlier this summer, year-to-date shootings in 2026 were slightly

up compared with last year.

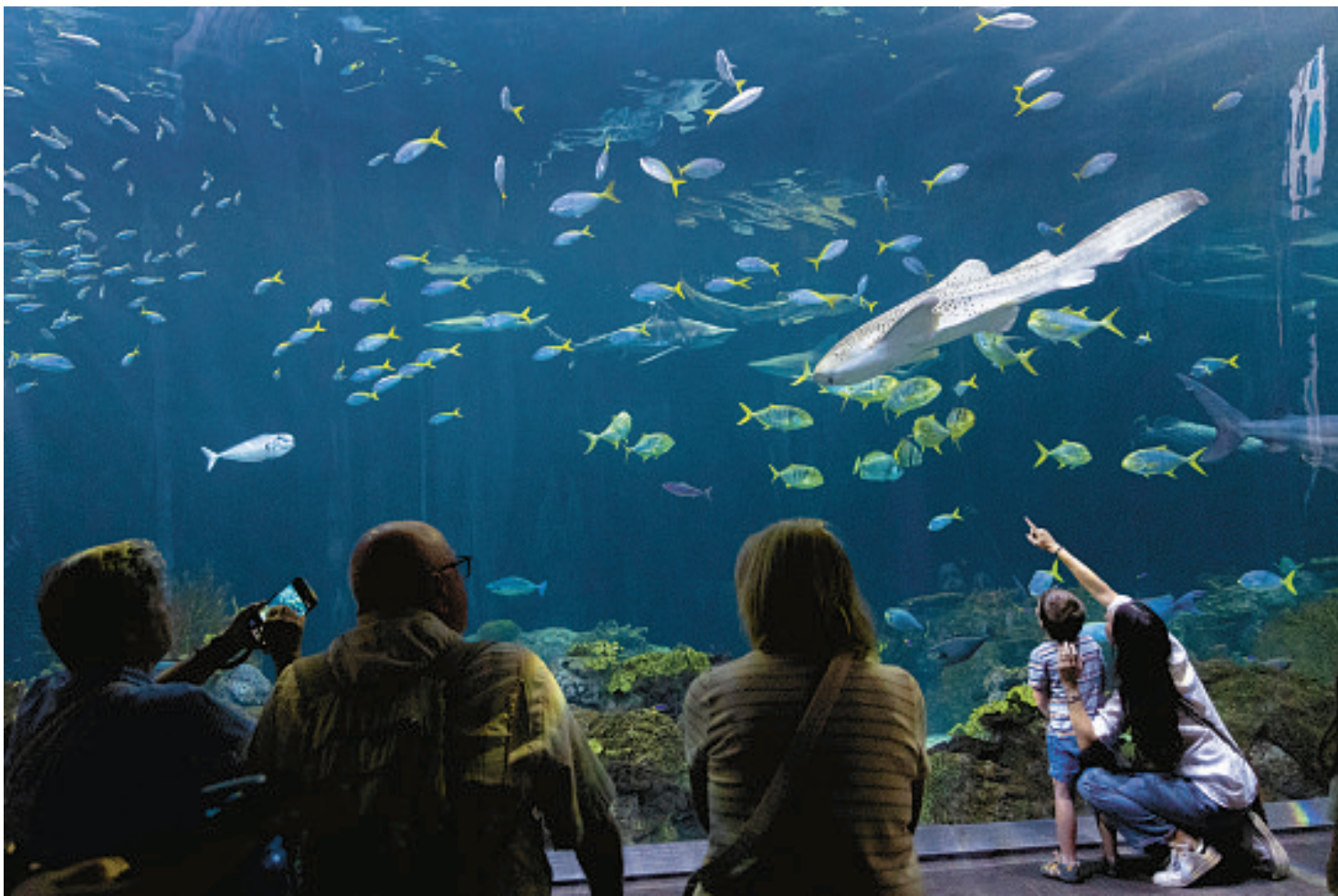
“That was a moment in time when we taped that video,” she said. “At the end of the day ... I don’t think any amount of shootings is acceptable.”

The city experienced a historic peak of 719 homicides in 2022, a year before Johnson took office, and ended last year with 416, according to Chicago police statistics. In the same time, shootings plunged 48%, robberies 35% and car thefts 20% — and those levels

have generally improved or held this year. It’s part of a broader trend that has seen violent crime plummet in cities across the U.S. in recent years, but one Johnson has regularly attributed to his own choices.

Despite the clear-cut improvements during Johnson’s time in office, nearly every declared mayoral candidate said in interviews with the Tribune that he has done too little to address violence.

See ELECTION on Page A4



An Indo-Pacific leopard shark, aka zebra shark, swims past a crowd at the Shedd Aquarium’s Wild Reef exhibit on Aug. 21. The Shedd recently sent four zebra shark eggs to Indonesia in an attempt to rewild the endangered fish. **ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

For Shedd Aquarium, shark week isn’t over

Facility sends 4 zebra shark eggs to Indonesia in rewilding efforts



A zebra shark swims at the Shedd Aquarium’s Wild Reef on Aug. 21.

By Adriana Pérez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Backlit with the beams from a flashlight, a figure came into view inside the leathery sac. Called a mermaid’s purse because of its shape and size, the zebra shark egg’s translucence revealed an embryo.

“See it wiggling around in there?” said Anna Byczynski, an aquarist and supervisor of the Shedd Aquarium’s tropical marine habitats.

Scientists use this technique, called candling — which historically entailed holding up a burning candle — to assess the contents

of shark eggs for health, viability and genetic diversity.

After passing with flying colors, four of them — laid by the Shedd’s 30-year-old “super mom” Cleo in the Wild Reef exhibit — embarked on a 9,000-mile journey, tucked in bags of seawater inside Styrofoam coolers, from their first home next to Lake Michigan to the Indonesian archipelago of Raja Ampat.

The collection of more than 1,000 islands forms part of the so-called Coral Triangle, an area in the western Pacific and Indian oceans home to the richest concentration of marine biodi-

See SHEDD on Page A2

1 dead, 14 hurt in mass shooting

Washington Park incident is largest in Chicago this year

By Finnegan Belleau and Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A mass shooting in Washington Park Saturday night became the city’s largest of the year when Chicago police reported that a total of 15 people had been shot, leaving one man dead.

Just before midnight on the 5400 block of South Cottage Grove Avenue, police sources said a pair of unknown shooters dressed in all black and ski masks shot at the gathering from across the street, and that someone from the crowd returned fire. Officers later recovered 10 .40-caliber casings on the east side of Cottage Grove and another 26 shell casings, including rifle casings, in the park itself, sources said.

The 35-year-old man who was shot was pronounced dead at the University of Chicago Medical Center, according to police. The Cook County medical examiner’s office later identified him as Rontonio M. Guterz, of the River North neighborhood.

CPD said fourteen more victims were injured: A 47-year-old woman who was listed in serious condition, four people in fair condition, and six in good condition. The status of three more victims was unknown, according to police. Area 1 detectives are investigating.

Ald. Jeanette Taylor, who represents Washington Park, said she drove past the incident twice Saturday. The first time was on her way to an event, and Taylor said lots of people and cars were gathered for festivities. Driving back home, she said South Cottage Grove Avenue was “very chaotic,” with police present and cars on grass.

“People were enjoying themselves; there was music; there was eating and laughing,” Taylor said.

See SHOOTING on Page A2

Official: US hits Iran rocket launchers

Attack along strait said to be military’s 1st strike in month

By Konstantin Toropin, Cara Anna and Ben Finley
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — U.S. forces struck Iranian rocket launchers on the Strait of Hormuz in their first military action in a month on Sunday, breaking a lull in fighting during an intermittent war that has lasted more than six months.

Iran swiftly vowed to retaliate for what it called a deadly attack, with reports that it fired missiles at U.S. forces in Jordan.

Troops with the Revolutionary Guard Corps were observed preparing to launch rockets with sea mines into the strait, according to Tim Hawkins, a spokesperson for the U.S. Central Command. The U.S. military last week completed clearing sea mines from the strait’s international shipping routes.

Semiofficial news outlets in Iran reported sounds of explosions near Larak island on the strait. The

Guard in a statement carried by Iran’s state broadcaster noted “the martyrdom and injury of several of our fighters and compatriots.” Guard spokesperson Gen. Hossein Mohebi said Sunday’s attack was a “fatal mistake by the Trump regime during the economic war” and the enemy will pay the consequences militarily and economically.

Later, Iranian state television showed what it said were ballistic missiles being fired by Iran at U.S. bases in Jordan in response to the American strikes. Jordan’s

armed forces said they intercepted eight missiles that penetrated its airspace early Monday.

A return to open conflict would be dangerous for the region, where Iran has targeted U.S. military bases in Gulf countries since the war began on Feb. 28.

The last time the U.S. military confirmed targeting Iran was on July 29, when it announced a “heavy wave of strikes” on dozens of Revolutionary Guard targets. On Aug. 1, President Donald Trump

See IRAN on Page A4



Bears general manager Ryan Poles. **JOHN J. KIM/TRIBUNE**

After cuts, roster questions remain

The Bears got down to the 53-man limit after making some tough decisions, including waiving cornerback Terell Smith.

Sports

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 90 L: 74
TUE. H: 91 L: 75
WED. H: 93 L: 74
FULL WEATHER REPORT, PAGE A10

INDEX

Almanac A8
Arts & Living B5
Comics B8-B9
Crossword B9
Editorials A5
Horoscope B8
Nation & World B1
Obituaries A8
Television B7

179th year No. 243
© Chicago Tribune

